kilometres, in a marathon-like 150-plus days, walking from Kanyakumari to Kashmir! The sheer audacity of doing something so bold in the face of the most challenging times marked by hate and divisive politics shook everyone out of their reverie. Its main slogan, '*Mile Kadam, Jude Watan* (Walk together, unite the country)', is deeply rooted in India's culture of struggle and the time-honoured tradition of reconnecting with the masses, and genuinely offered a glimmer of hope amid the gloom.

Even more impressive was Rahul Gandhi's decision to embark on this padyatra. In contrast to his image of a princeling from a privileged background, his decision reflects an indomitable spirit and a refusal to capitulate even in the face of relentless personal attacks, slander and abuse —an experience unmatched by most political leaders. This is perhaps a testament to his transformation. He no longer represents just himself, the 'family', or the Congress. He now embodies the spirit of the entire country, each one of us, and his future is inexorably intertwined with the future of the nation. His resolve to heal the nation and give it hope, albeit softly but resolutely, emanates from the legacy that he inherits and the many painful, but profound lessons learnt throughout his life and within his immediate family.

However, a fear lurked within me. Could he truly pull off this extraordinary feat? A 4,000-kilometre journey spanning 150 days, accompanied by a hundred co-yatris, is no easy task. Each day would demand his unwavering attention, stretching for hours as he interacted with countless individuals who yearned for a moment of connection with him and the Yatra. What if he faltered along the way, succumbing to fatigue or illness? What if disaster struck? The weight of these 'what ifs' pressed heavily on my mind. Failure would not only impact him, but could spell the end of his leadership.

As I grappled with these concerns from my vantage point, far from the epicentre of Indian politics, it became clear that the success of this historic journey depended on our collective commitment. I decided that I, too, would walk, covering as much distance as my body would allow. This was